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Flock Cameras Need Regulation, Controlled Access, & Safeguards

Mary Alice Adams, Azalea Privacy Alliance
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To the Editor:

This letter addresses mass surveillance which involves use of cameras positioned on our public streets.

The cameras employ AI-powered automated license plate readers (ALPRs). They capture vehicle make, model, color, license plate, bumper stickers, and timestamps of all vehicles which pass before them whether the persons surveilled are suspected of a crime or not. Data collected enters a searchable, centralized network accessible to law enforcement agencies across the country. With this technology, movement of any vehicle scanned can be tracked and recorded.

Virtually unregulated use of this mass surveillance technology has contributed to numerous instances of law enforcement officers being accused or convicted of misusing the database to illegally track romantic partners, members of the opposite sex in whom they have sexual interest, family members, enemies, and acquaintances. Some of those offenders have been in Georgia.

The leading company in the public surveillance industry is Flock Group Inc., doing business as Flock Safety (or “Flock”), which is based in Atlanta. Flock operates its system under contract with law enforcement agencies and local governments. Flock says it operates in over 6,000 communities across 49 U.S. states, and performs over 20 billion scans of vehicles in the U.S. every month (according to Wikipedia).

Both Thomaston and Upson County have contracted with Flock to install its system here. Flock has installed at least 24 cameras in the City of Thomason and Upson County. There may be more. Both local governments pay Flock on an annual basis to install its equipment and operate its system.

Flock has recognized there is a problem with the system being abused. It says it has rolled out changes to its system to prevent this from happening again. However, these changes fail to address the underlying systemic problem which contributed to those abuses. That problem is complete lack of any sort of independent oversight or gate keeper to regulate access to the Flock camera database.

Despite Flock’s changes, ultimate responsibility for deciding which requests for access should be granted remains vested with the requesting law enforcement agencies themselves. Heads of those agencies have an institutional bias and conflict of interest which disqualify them from making impartial determinations as to whether requests for access should be granted.

Law enforcement agencies are only one part of local government involved in developing policies which govern surveillance. As Flock’s CEO recently stated, “We should continue to rely on our locally elected officials to make these trade-offs of how we keep the community safe.” See Garrett Langley’s Aug. 19, 2026 interview Proton Team at <https://proton.me/blog/flock-ceo-interview>.

Our local governments should mandate reasonable regulation and control of access to the Flock camera database and implementation of appropriate safeguards to prevent future abuses. They include:

- Appointment of an independent ombudsman, a gatekeeper not employed by law enforcement, to decide when access to the Flock camera database should be granted.
- Improved record keeping.
- Public access to those records.
- Reporting requirements for abuses of the system.
- Prominent signage to alert citizens to location of Flock cameras.

These measures will ensure our mass surveillance camera systems are operated in an open and transparent manner, prevent future abuses of the system, and provide accountability for any government officer who attempts to abuse the system.

Respectfully submitted,

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